

SHOULDER PAIN

TIPS & STRETCHES TO HELP YOU FEEL BETTER



Shoulder pain can be caused by muscle strain, tendon irritation, or overuse. These tips and exercises can help reduce pain, improve mobility, and restore function.



REST, BUT STAY GENTLY ACTIVE

Avoid activities that increase pain, but gentle movement helps prevent stiffness. Find a balance between rest and activity.



ICE OR HEAT

Use ice for 15–20 minutes to reduce pain and swelling in the first 48–72 hours. After that, heat can help relax muscles and improve flexibility.



AVOID OVERHEAD ACTIVITIES

Limit lifting, reaching, or repetitive movements above shoulder height until your pain improves.



USE PAIN RELIEVERS AS NEEDED

Over-the-counter pain relievers like ibuprofen or acetaminophen can help with pain and inflammation. Take as directed.



MAINTAIN GOOD POSTURE

Keep your shoulders relaxed and your posture upright. Avoid slouching, which can strain your shoulder.



STRENGTHEN GRADUALLY

Strengthening the muscles around your shoulder helps support the joint and prevent future pain.



BE PATIENT & CONSISTENT

Healing takes time. Consistent stretches and exercises are key to a full recovery.

WHEN TO SEEK CARE

Seek medical attention if you experience:

- Severe pain or swelling
- Inability to lift your arm
- Numbness, tingling, or weakness in your arm or hand
- Shoulder that feels unstable or “gives out”
- Pain that worsens or does not improve within a few days



It's normal for improvement to be gradual. Small, consistent steps lead to better results!

GENTLE EXERCISES FOR SHOULDER PAIN

1 PENDULUM (CODMAN)



- Lean forward and support yourself with your non-injured arm.
- Let your injured arm hang down relaxed.
- Gently swing your arm in small circles, then back and forth, then side to side.
- Do for 30–60 seconds each direction.
- Repeat 2–3 times daily.

2 CROSSOVER ARM STRETCH



- Bring your injured arm across your body at shoulder height.
- Use your other arm to gently pull it closer.
- You should feel a stretch in the back of your shoulder.
- Hold for 20–30 seconds.
- Repeat 2–3 times.

3 INTERNAL & EXTERNAL ROTATION (WITH RESISTANCE BAND)

INTERNAL ROTATION



- Keep your elbow at your side and bent to 90°.
- Pull the band toward your stomach.
- Do 10–15 reps.
- Repeat 2–3 sets.

EXTERNAL ROTATION



- Keep your elbow at your side and bent to 90°.
- Pull the band away from your body.
- Do 10–15 reps.
- Repeat 2–3 sets.

Tip: Move slowly and keep your elbow tucked close to your side.

4 SLEEPER STRETCH



- Lie on your side with your injured shoulder down.
- Bend your arm to 90° in front of you.
- Use your other hand to gently push your wrist down toward the surface.
- You should feel a stretch in the back of your shoulder.
- Hold for 20–30 seconds.
- Repeat 2–3 times.



Mild discomfort is normal, but exercises should not cause sharp pain. Stop if pain increases and consult a healthcare provider.

IF YOUR SYMPTOMS PERSIST OR WORSEN, PLEASE FOLLOW UP WITH YOUR PROVIDER.

This handout is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice. Always consult your healthcare provider with any questions or concerns.